

Their agent of choice is impressed by how willing and able they are to transact on a home, so she's happy to work with them even though it might take a bit more time than the typical transaction. She confirms that \$360,000 is a great price for what they want, and she sets them up to receive listings from the MLS that meet their needs.

As listings pop up on the MLS, Alex and Shelby run the numbers for any house that piques their interest. Is it the priciest house in the neighborhood, or is it the "worst" house in the neighborhood? Is it primed to increase in value, through both market and forced appreciation? Can the property be turned into a cash-flowing rental should they choose to do so in the future? If a house doesn't meet all these needs, that's not necessarily a deal breaker, but it is a piece of information that the couple factors into their decision-making process.

After a few weeks of viewing homes, they finally find one suitable enough to make an offer. That offer isn't accepted, but they don't give up. After making two more offers on homes that meet their needs, they finally go under contract! It's a three-bedroom, two-bathroom home in one of their preferred neighborhoods with an updated kitchen and a two-car garage, all for the offer price of \$350,000 (which is \$10,000 less than their maximum price, thanks to their agent's great advice).

They let their lender know they're under contract, give their earnest money to the title company, and set up a home inspection for the following week. Though the inspector makes it sound like everything is wrong with the home, his overall opinion is that the house is in good condition—except for the very old roof. Alex and Shelby decide to include the cost of roof repairs in their inspection objection notice, and after some negotiating, the seller agrees to give them a credit at closing to cover the costs.

Everything else happens in a blur: They perform all their due diligence, check for any clouds on the title, and choose a home insurance company. The appraisal comes back right at their \$350,000 asking price. They lock in their interest rate with their lender, and the loan is finalized. Before Alex and Shelby know it, they are sitting at the title company with pens in hand. An hour of signatures later, they are proud homeowners!

As time goes on, the couple makes their \$2,200 monthly payments with ease, and as they predicted, there's plenty of money to cover all costs while still building their savings and retirement accounts. They use the cash they